

Handout: *Craig and Moreland on The Kalam Cosmological Argument*

I. The Problem and the Proposed Solution

The Problem

Craig and Moreland begin with a fundamental metaphysical question:

Why does the universe exist?

More specifically:

- Is the universe **eternal**, existing without beginning?
- Is it **metaphysically necessary**, existing by its own nature?
- Or is it **contingent**, dependent upon some external cause?

The broader problem is framed within the tradition of **cosmological arguments**, which seek a **Sufficient Reason**, **First Cause**, or **Ground of Being** for the cosmos.

Craig and Moreland argue that:

- If the universe began to exist,
- And whatever begins to exist has a cause,
- Then the universe must have a **transcendent cause**.

Their solution is the **Kalam Cosmological Argument**, which aims to show that:

1. The universe had a beginning.
 2. Therefore, it has a cause.
 3. That cause possesses the attributes traditionally ascribed to **God**.
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II. The Cosmological Argument Family: Setting the Stage

Craig and Moreland situate the kalam argument within three major types of cosmological reasoning:

1. Thomist Cosmological Argument (Aquinas)

- Seeks a sustaining **Ground of Being**
- Based on the metaphysical composition of **essence and existence**
- Argues for *ipsum esse subsistens* (pure act of being)

2. Leibnizian Cosmological Argument

- Based on the **Principle of Sufficient Reason (PSR)**
- Every existing thing has an explanation
- Concludes that there must be a **metaphysically necessary being**

3. Kalam Cosmological Argument (Focus of the Reading)

- Argues from the **beginning of the universe**
- Rooted in medieval Islamic philosophy (al-Ghazali, al-Kindi)
- Strengthened by modern cosmology

Craig and Moreland consider these in reverse order, ultimately presenting the kalam argument as both:

- An independent proof
 - A supplement to the Leibnizian argument
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III. The Structure of the Kalam Argument

The core syllogism:

1. **Whatever begins to exist has a cause.**
2. **The universe began to exist.**
3. Therefore, **the universe has a cause.**

The rest of the paper defends both premises and then analyzes the nature of the cause.

IV. Defense of Premise (1): Whatever Begins to Exist Has a Cause

A. Metaphysical Intuition

Premise (1) is grounded in the principle:

Ex nihilo nihil fit — from nothing, nothing comes.

Craig argues:

- This is not a physical principle (like gravity).
- It is a **metaphysical principle**.
- It applies to *all reality*, not just to things within the universe.

B. Objection: Quantum Physics

Critics claim:

- Subatomic events are uncaused.
- The universe could arise from a “quantum vacuum.”

Craig responds:

- Not all interpretations of quantum mechanics are indeterministic.
- Even indeterministic quantum events arise from a **quantum vacuum**, which is *not nothing*.
- The vacuum is a sea of fluctuating energy governed by physical laws.

Thus, quantum theory does not show something arising from literal nothingness.

C. The Time Theory Debate (A-Theory vs. B-Theory)

This section is philosophically crucial.

Craig presupposes an **A-theory of time**:

- Temporal becoming is real.
- The present is objectively distinct.

- The universe literally *came into being*.

On a **B-theory (tenseless theory)**:

- All times equally exist.
- The universe is a four-dimensional block.
- The universe does not “come into being.”

Craig argues that premise (1) requires the A-theory. Thus, the debate hinges on:

Is temporal becoming objectively real?

V. Defense of Premise (2): The Universe Began to Exist

Craig offers **four arguments**:

1. The Impossibility of an Actual Infinite (pp. 181–183)

Key Distinction:

- **Actual infinite:** A completed set with infinitely many members.
- **Potential infinite:** A process that can increase without limit.

Craig argues:

- An actual infinite cannot exist in reality.
- An infinite temporal regress of events would be an actual infinite.
- Therefore, the past cannot be infinite.

Hilbert's Hotel

The famous thought experiment:

- A hotel with infinitely many rooms.
- Fully occupied.
- Still can accommodate new guests.

- Infinite guests can check out — yet no change in number.
- Removing certain guests yields absurd results.

Conclusion:

An actually infinite number of concrete objects leads to metaphysical absurdities.

Craig insists this does not challenge Cantorian set theory — only its application to real, spatiotemporal reality.

2. The Impossibility of Forming an Actual Infinite by Successive Addition (pp. 183–185)

The past is formed by successive addition:

- Event after event
- One moment following another

But:

- A collection formed by successive addition cannot be actually infinite.
- You cannot “traverse” an infinite past to arrive at the present.

Tristram Shandy Paradox

- Shandy writes his autobiography at one year per day.
- If he has been writing from eternity, absurd consequences follow.
- He would never reach the present.

Conclusion:

An infinite regress of past events is impossible because it could never be completed.

3. The Expansion of the Universe (Big Bang Cosmology) (pp. 185–187)

Using Einstein, Friedman, Lemaître, and Hubble:

- The universe is expanding.
- Reversing expansion leads to a singularity.
- Space-time itself begins at the Big Bang.

Important claim:

The Big Bang represents an absolute origin **ex nihilo**.

Space, time, matter, and energy all begin at the singularity.

Craig emphasizes:

- No physical cause could precede it.
- The beginning is not just a rearrangement — it is an origin of space-time itself.

4. The Second Law of Thermodynamics (pp. 187–188)

Entropy increases in a closed system.

If the universe were eternal:

- It would already be in heat death.
- But it is not.

Therefore:

- The universe has not existed forever.
- It must have had a beginning.

Even oscillating universe models fail, because entropy would accumulate across cycles.

VI. What Must the Cause Be Like?

From the conclusion — “The universe has a cause” — Craig performs a conceptual analysis.

The cause must be:

- **Transcendent** (beyond space and time)
- **Atemporal**

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- **Immaterial**
 - **Uncaused**
 - **Enormously powerful**

But most importantly:

The Cause Must Be Personal

Craig offers three arguments:

1. Only Two Types of Explanation Exist:

- Scientific (laws + initial conditions)
- Personal (agent + volition)

Since no prior physical state exists, only a **personal explanation** is possible.

2. Only Minds or Abstract Objects Are Timeless

- Abstract objects cannot cause anything.
 - Therefore, the cause must be a **mind**.
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3. A Timeless Cause Producing a Temporal Effect

If the cause were a set of necessary and sufficient conditions:

- The effect would be eternal as well.

Only a **free personal agent** can:

- Exist timelessly
- Will a temporal effect to begin

Thus:

The cause of the universe is a personal Creator.
